

Wednesday, 15 July 2026.

Your daily radio show prep — three top news stories, forward-looking showbiz, sport that matters this week, talkback prompts, and day notes for today and tomorrow. Built fresh every weekday, ready by 3pm for tomorrow's show.

00 — WEATHER

Tomorrow's forecast

LONDON	BIRMINGHAM	MANCHESTER
Mostly clear	Overcast	Clear
29° 18°	28° 15°	27° 15°

01 — NEWS

Today's top stories

- 1

A murder investigation is underway in Northern Ireland after three people, including an eight-year-old girl, were found dead in a family home.

Police were called to a property in Ballymena on Monday, where the three individuals were discovered. Officers are now working to establish the circumstances surrounding the tragic deaths.

CRIME · UK
- 2

A man who staged his wife's suicide has been jailed for her murder, with their daughter calling him a 'jealous, conniving villain'.

The court heard harrowing details of the case, as the daughter bravely spoke out against her father. This tragic case highlights the devastating impact of such crimes on families.

CRIME · UK
- 3

No action will be taken against a farmer after a teenager was fatally shot during a burglary at his property.

The farmer had been arrested after 19-year-old Marcus Smith sustained a fatal gunshot wound in 2024. The decision follows an investigation into the incident.

CRIME · UK
- 4

A new report warns that pupils receiving free school meals are falling further behind their peers in education.

The Education Policy Institute is urging the new Prime Minister to tackle this issue with a 'laser-like focus'. It highlights growing concerns about educational inequality across the UK.

EDUCATION · UK
- 5

Families of those killed in the 1994 RAF Chinook crash are asking the court to allow their case to proceed.

The helicopter crash in the Mull of Kintyre claimed the lives of 25 passengers and four crew members. The families have been seeking answers and justice for decades.

INVESTIGATION · UK

What's coming up

1 **Ed Sheeran is inspiring a new government-backed scheme to bring music rehearsal spaces and studios into local libraries.**

The pop star will help design the programme, aiming to make music more accessible to communities. It's a fantastic initiative to nurture new talent and creativity.

ON AIR – What a brilliant idea! Do you think more libraries should become community hubs for creative pursuits?

MUSIC · UPCOMING

2 **A British teenager has seen off 300,000 competitors to become one of the new generation of 'Cheetah Girls'.**

The popular group is making a comeback, and this young star has earned her spot through sheer talent. It's a huge opportunity for her to shine!

ON AIR – Remember The Cheetah Girls? Are you excited to see a new generation take on the iconic roles?

TV & FILM · UPCOMING

3 **Andy Serkis has defended the casting choices for the new 'Lord of the Rings' series, addressing concerns about diversity.**

Stars like Kate Winslet, Jamie Dornan, and Anya Taylor-Joy are already confirmed for the highly anticipated show. Serkis believes the cast reflects the story's needs.

ON AIR – With such a huge fan base, do you think new adaptations of classic stories should always aim for diverse casting?

TV & FILM · UPCOMING

4 **California is leading a lawsuit to block the proposed mega-merger between Paramount and Warner Bros.**

The state, home to both studio headquarters, has joined 11 others to try and halt the deal. This could have massive implications for the future of Hollywood.

ON AIR – A huge shake-up in Hollywood! Do you think these big studio mergers are good or bad for the film industry?

TV & FILM · UPCOMING

5 **The Bayeux Tapestry is being explored through five key scenes, revealing the medieval game of thrones between William the Conqueror and King Harold.**

This historical artwork vividly depicts the dramatic battles and political intrigue of 1066. It's a fascinating look back at a pivotal moment in British history.

ON AIR – The Bayeux Tapestry tells such a dramatic story! What piece of history would you love to see depicted in a similar way?

HISTORY · ONGOING

On the schedule

1 **The Open Championship could move Sunday's final round tee times to avoid clashing with the World Cup final, if England make it.**

It's a huge weekend for sport, and organisers are clearly thinking ahead. Imagine the dilemma of choosing between two massive sporting events!

ON AIR – If England make the World Cup final, would you rather watch that or The Open? What a choice!

GOLF · UK

2 **France and Spain are set for a World Cup semi-final showdown, pitting young sensation Lamine Yamal against superstar Kylian Mbappe.**

It's a clash of titans for a place in the final, promising an electrifying match. Football fans are buzzing about this one!

ON AIR – Mbappe versus Yamal – who do you think will come out on top in this epic World Cup semi-final?

FOOTBALL · INTERNATIONAL

3 **American referee Ismail Elfath has been announced as the official for England's World Cup semi-final against Argentina.**

Some fans are already calling him Lionel Messi's 'lucky charm' after previous matches. It adds another layer of intrigue to an already massive game.

ON AIR – A referee with a reputation for being a 'lucky charm' for Messi... do you think that adds extra pressure on England?

FOOTBALL · INTERNATIONAL

4 **Jannik Sinner has retained his Wimbledon title, defeating Alexander Zverev in four sets in the men's singles final.**

The world number one delivered another incredible performance on Centre Court. It's a fantastic achievement for the talented player.

ON AIR – Sinner has done it again at Wimbledon! Who do you think is the most dominant player in tennis right now?

TENNIS · UK

5 **Brighton have signed Croatian defender Luka Vuskovic from Tottenham for a club record fee of £46 million.**

It's a massive investment for Brighton, securing a highly-rated young talent on a five-year contract. This could be a game-changer for their defence.

ON AIR – Brighton breaking their club record for a defender! Which Premier League club do you think has made the smartest signing this transfer window?

FOOTBALL · UK

Quick hits

- 1 The delightful art of 'porch parcels' is bringing smiles to neighbourhoods across the country.**
Residents are leaving small, thoughtful gifts like homemade biscuits or a new book on their neighbours' doorsteps, creating a lovely sense of community spirit without needing an occasion.
- 2 A new appreciation for the simple joy of 'window gazing' is gaining traction.**
Many are discovering the calming effect of simply watching the world go by from a favourite window, noticing the small details they usually miss in their busy lives.
- 3 The trend of 'urban bird-watching' is soaring in popularity.**
City dwellers are finding immense pleasure in identifying and observing the various bird species that share their urban environments, often right from their own gardens or balconies.
- 4 Rediscovering the charm of 'local noticeboards' is becoming a sweet pastime.**
Instead of scrolling online, people are enjoying browsing physical noticeboards for local events, lost pets, and community news, connecting with their immediate area in a tangible way.
- 5 The humble 'teacup' is making a grand comeback as a versatile decorative item.**
Beyond just brewing, vintage and quirky teacups are being repurposed as mini planters, candle holders, or even charming desk tidies, adding a touch of whimsy to any room.
- 6 A charming movement encouraging people to 'read to their house plants' is blossoming.**
Proponents suggest that the gentle human voice creates a soothing environment, and many report feeling a deeper connection to their green companions.
- 7 The satisfying craft of 'basket weaving' is experiencing a quiet revival.**
More individuals are turning to this ancient skill, finding joy and relaxation in creating beautiful, functional items from natural materials, often sourced locally.

05 – TALKBACK

For the phone lines

OUR SURVEY SAID

Q Our survey said that over 60% of us admit to secretly 'doing' what when we're trying to find something we've misplaced around the house?

ANSWER: TALKING TO THE LOST ITEM, AS IF IT CAN HEAR US!

Q Our survey said that over 55% of us admit to having a particular 'food combination' that absolutely everyone else finds a bit odd, but you love?

ANSWER: CRISPS DIPPED IN CHOCOLATE, OR PERHAPS JAM ON A SAUSAGE ROLL!

TALK TOPIC

- You know how sometimes you stumble upon a 'tiny, forgotten corner' of a park or a walking trail that feels like your own secret garden?

Have you ever found a hidden gem like that, and what made it so special?

- We all have those 'little everyday sounds' that just make us feel instantly happy and content, don't we?

What's a specific everyday sound that brings a smile to your face, and why?

TRUE STORY OR JACKANORY – LISTENERS GUESS

FACT **History.** The ancient Romans used to use crushed mice brains as a toothpaste ingredient.

FICTION **Made up, but believable.** The first public clock in London was installed in 1345, but it only told the time between sunrise and sunset.

06 – LOTTERY

Jackpots ahead

NEXT EUROMILLIONS JACKPOT

£7.6 million

Next Tuesday or Friday · estimated

NEXT NATIONAL LOTTERY JACKPOT

£7.6 million

Next Wednesday or Saturday · estimated

07 – FACTS OF THE DAY

Did you know?

- A group of owls is called a parliament.
- The inventor of the Pringle, Fredric Baur, requested to be buried in one of the iconic chip cans.
- Butterflies taste with their feet.
- The world's largest officially measured snowflake was 15 inches wide and 8 inches thick, found in Montana in 1887.
- It is illegal to sing out of tune in Maryland, USA, in public.
- The 'richest' bird's nest in the world belongs to the Sociable Weaver, which can house hundreds of birds and weigh over a ton.
- There are more permutations of a deck of 52 playing cards than there are atoms on Earth.
- Penguins are the only birds that can swim but not fly.

On this day

Day 196 of the year, 169 days left in 2026. Today Christian feast day: Abhai (Syriac Orthodox Church); Christian feast day: Anne-Marie Javouhey; Christian feast day: Bernhard II, Margrave of Baden-Baden; Christian feast day: Bonaventure. Star sign Cancer, birthstone Ruby.

TODAY'S BIRTHDAYS

- 1971 — Jim Rash, American actor, comedian, and filmmaker
- 1948 — Twinkle, English singer-songwriter (died 2015)
- 1952 — David Pack, American singer-songwriter, guitarist, and producer
- 1953 — Alicia Bridges, American singer-songwriter
- 1956 — Joe Satriani, American singer-songwriter and guitarist
- 1952 — Terry O'Quinn, American actor
- 1952 — Johnny Thunders, American singer-songwriter and guitarist (died 1991)
- 1951 — Jesse Ventura, American wrestler, actor, and politician, 38th Governor of Minnesota

THE DAY TODAY

- 2012 — South Korean rapper Psy releases his hit single Gangnam Style.
- 1974 — In Nicosia, Cyprus, Greek junta-sponsored nationalists launch a coup d'état, deposing Makarios III and installing Nikos Sampson as the president of Cyprus.
- 2009 — Space Shuttle program: Endeavour is launched on STS-127 to complete assembly of the International Space Station's Kibō module.

TODAY IN MUSIC

- 1888 — The stratovolcano Mount Bandai erupts, killing approximately 500 people in Fukushima Prefecture, Japan.
- 1927 — Massacre of July 15, 1927: Eighty-nine protesters are killed by Austrian police in Vienna.

TODAY IN HISTORY

- 2009 — Space Shuttle program: Endeavour is launched on STS-127 to complete assembly of the International Space Station's Kibō module.
- 1966 — Vietnam War: The United States and South Vietnam begin Operation Hastings to push the North Vietnamese out of the Vietnamese Demilitarized Zone.

- 2002 — The Anti-Terrorism Court of Pakistan sentences British born Ahmed Omar Saeed Sheikh to death, and three others suspected of murdering The Wall Street Journal reporter Daniel Pearl to life.

A peek at tomorrow

Day 197 of the year, 168 days left in 2026. Today Christian feast day: André de Soveral; Christian feast day: Gondulphus of Tongeren; Christian feast day: Helier; Christian feast day: Blessed Irmgard of Chiemsee. Star sign Cancer, birthstone Ruby.

TOMORROW'S BIRTHDAYS

- 1937 — John Daly, English director, producer, and screenwriter (died 2008)
- 1939 — William Bell, American singer-songwriter
- 1957 — Faye Grant, American actress
- 1928 — Anita Brookner, English novelist and art historian (died 2016)
- 2004 — Amiah Miller, American actress and model
- 1927 — Derek Hawke, English footballer (died 2021)
- 1927 — Shirley Hughes, English author and illustrator (died 2022)
- 1983 — Katrina Kaif, British Indian actress and model

THE DAY TOMORROW

- 2004 — Millennium Park, considered Chicago's first and most ambitious early 21st-century architectural project, is opened to the public by Mayor Richard M. Daley.
- 2005 — An Antonov An-24 crashes near Baney in Bioko Norte, Equatorial Guinea, killing 60 people.
- 1990 — The Luzon earthquake strikes the Philippines with an intensity of 7.7, affecting Benguet, Pangasinan, Nueva Ecija, La Union, Aurora, Bataan, Zambales and Tarlac.

TOMORROW IN MUSIC

- 2013 — Syrian civil war: The Battle of Ras al-Ayn resumes between the People's Protection Units (YPG) and Islamist forces, beginning the Rojava–Islamist conflict.
- 1957 — KLM Flight 844 crashes off the Schouten Islands in present day Indonesia (then Netherlands New Guinea), killing 58 people.

Coming to cinemas

JULY 2026

FRI 17	Christopher Nolan's The Odyssey (+ IMAX); Cut Off
FRI 24	Heads of State; Untitled DCU
FRI 31	Spider-Man: Brand New Day

AUGUST 2026

FRI 7	Once Upon a Time in a Cinema
FRI 14	Flowervale Street; PAW Patrol 3: The Dino Movie
FRI 21	Mutiny; The Bride!
FRI 28	Crime 101; Outcome

SEPTEMBER 2026 • PREVIEW

FRI 4	Conjuring: Last Rites
FRI 11	Resident Evil reboot
FRI 18	The Black Phone 2
FRI 25	Tron: Ares (+ IMAX)

OCTOBER 2026 • PREVIEW

FRI 16	Untitled Christopher McQuarrie thriller
FRI 23	Frankenstein (del Toro)

On the sporting calendar

JULY 2026	
4–26 JUL	Tour de France (Cycling)
16–19 JUL	The Open Championship (Golf)
18–26 JUL	World Matchplay Darts, Blackpool
23 JUL – 2 AUG	Commonwealth Games, Glasgow
AUGUST 2026	
W/C 10	Hundred & T20 Blast climax (Cricket)
SAT 15	Premier League season begins (2026/27)
22–23	Belgian Grand Prix (F1)